

Chapter 1

Snow basics

Snow is a fundamental component of the cryosphere, which encompasses all regions of the Earth where water exists in solid form. Alongside sea ice, glaciers, ice caps and ice sheets, snow cover plays an essential role in regulating Earth's climate by reflecting a significant fraction of the incoming solar radiation, consequently reducing the amount of energy absorbed by the ground. In addition, snow also acts as a thermal insulator due to its low thermal conductivity, protecting the soil and the ecosystem from the abrupt temperature fluctuations typical of winter. Snow is also a key factor in the hydrological cycle: water stored in solid form during winter is gradually released into streamflow through spring and summer, ensuring a continuous water supply and mitigating the severity of certain droughts. At the same time, snow has considerable implications for human activities. For instance, it plays a vital role in the economy of the Alpine region by supporting winter tourism through skiing and other winter sports. Its contribution to runoff is equally important, as it supports irrigation and provides a source of drinking water. Meltwater also provides a substantial contribution to hydropower generation. With the ongoing climate change, these dynamics are expected to shift, making the understanding and modelling of snow related processes increasingly important. Earlier snowmelt and reduced solid water storage are among the most direct consequences of a temperature rise, with potential repercussions for multiple aspects of human civilization. The aim of this chapter is therefore to provide a broad overview of snow dynamics, before focusing on snow measurement techniques, which are essential to assess the state of the snowpack.

1.1 Snow physics and dynamics

The formation of snow is the result of a chain of microphysical processes occurring within clouds, from initial ice nucleation to the eventual fall of snowflakes to the ground.

For the atmosphere to release its water content, whether in liquid or solid form, the air must first reach a state of supersaturation with respect to water or ice. This condition is typically achieved through upward motion of air masses which causes

adiabatic cooling of air parcels. The temperature drop strongly reduces air's capacity to hold water vapor, driving the parcel toward, and eventually beyond, saturation (Wallace and Hobbs 2006).

Snowfall can only be produced by clouds that extend above the 0°C level. Although temperatures within these cold clouds can drop well below freezing point, supercooled water droplets can still coexist with ice particles. The freezing process, known as ice nucleation, occurs through two different mechanisms:

- *homogeneous nucleation*, which occurs in pure water droplets without foreign particles. The first step in the freezing process is the formation of an ice embryo, which must exceed a critical size to produce a decrease in the free energy of the system. If this condition is met, the freezing process continues until the entire water droplet is turned into ice. The average size of the ice embryo increases as temperature decreases, so that below a certain threshold, which is around -40°C , freezing becomes almost certain. If homogeneous nucleation were the only mechanism responsible for ice particle formation, snowfall would be extremely rare at mid-latitudes. Since this is not the case, an additional mechanism is necessary.
- *heterogeneous nucleation*, which relies on the presence of a foreign particle. Cloud droplets typically contain such impurities acting as freezing nuclei. Their presence promotes the formation of an ice-like structure, thereby enabling freezing at temperatures considerably higher than those required for homogeneous nucleation. It is also possible for foreign particles not to be part of the water droplet itself, but instead to trigger freezing through contact or deposition. Regardless of the specific mechanism involved, the most effective ice nuclei are insoluble in water and have a crystallographic structure similar to ice.

Once nucleated, the ice particle grows through further microphysical processes, whose relative dominance determines its final shape and size. The three main crystal growth mechanisms are:

- *vapor deposition*, which occurs whenever the air is supersaturated with respect to ice. For example, in mixed-phase clouds dominated by supercooled droplets, vapor molecules are deposited onto the ice crystals, causing them to grow significantly faster than the surrounding water droplets. The growth rate reaches a maximum around -14°C , since at that temperature the difference between the saturated vapor pressure over water and over ice is largest, thus driving vapor molecules more effectively towards ice crystals. Studies on the growth of ice crystals by deposition have shown a strong relationship between

crystal shape and the temperature at which the growth process takes place. This strong temperature dependence produces an alternating pattern between plate-like and column-like ice particles, as shown in Figure 1.1.

- *riming*, which occurs exclusively in mixed-phase clouds. Whenever an ice crystal collides with a supercooled droplet, the latter may freeze onto the former, resulting in an increase in ice mass. The collision frequency depends on cloud density and composition, but typically numerous riming events take place, sometimes producing a graupel, namely an ice particle in which the original ice crystal can no longer be identified. Riming can also lead to the formation of hailstones, which typically range from a few millimeters to several centimetres in diameter.
- *aggregation*, caused by collisions between ice particles. The probability of adhesion is strongly linked to crystal shapes and increases with increasing temperature, reaching a maximum at around -5°C , where ice surfaces become particularly "sticky".

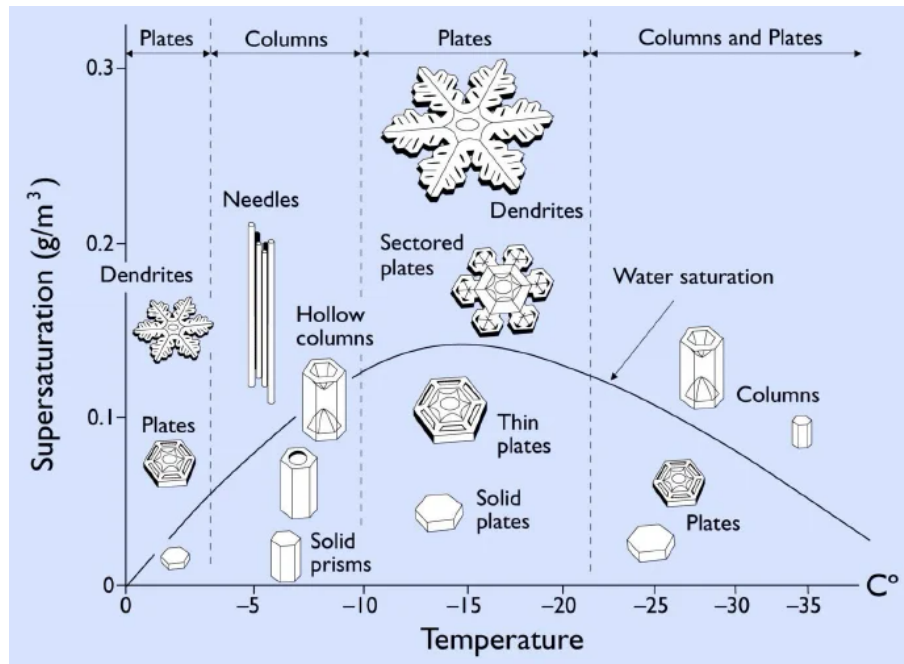


Figure 1.1: The Nakaya diagram illustrates the morphology of ice crystals growing via vapor deposition as a function of cloud's thermodynamic state. Crystal shape is primarily governed by temperature, which determines whether it develops in a planar or columnar structure, while the degree of supersaturation with respect to ice modulates the complexity of the resulting form, with higher supersaturations generally linked to more complex structures. Image taken from Libbrecht [2012](#).

Once an ice particle grows large enough to overcome updraft forces and turbulent motion within the cloud, it begins to fall toward the ground. The temperature profile encountered by the descending particle ultimately determines the type of precipitation that reaches the surface. For snowfall to occur, the snowflake, composed of up to hundreds of ice crystals, must remain predominantly below freezing and avoid melting completely before reaching the ground. Typically, snowflakes have fall rates of approximately 1.5 m s^{-1} . Snowfall amounts are measured either by depth or by snow water equivalent (SWE), defined as the height of the water column resulting from a complete melting of the snow. Snow depth typically increases of approximately 1 cm h^{-1} during snowfall events. Newly fallen snow density ranges from 20 kg m^{-3} to 300 kg m^{-3} depending on wind patterns and weather conditions, with higher temperatures generally leading to higher density values (Armstrong and Brun 2008).

1.1.1 Snow metamorphism and compaction

Accumulation of snowflakes on bare ground or atop older snow results in the formation of a new snow layer. Snow crystals form a solid matrix delimiting pores filled with humid air or liquid water or both, depending on layer temperature. This structure can be clearly appreciated in Figure 1.2, where the coexistence of the solid, liquid and gaseous phases of water is visible. Snow is thus a porous medium, whose properties are closely linked to its texture.

The arrangement of snow crystals evolves over time as a result of thermodynamic interactions among the constituents of the snow layer. This process, known as *snow metamorphism*, is strongly influenced by thermal and meteorological conditions. Since each layer within the snowpack is subject to different burial depths, temperature gradients and moisture presence, it follows a distinct metamorphic pathway. Consequently, the snowpack develops a stratified structure, with individual layers exhibiting different crystal characteristics.

A key factor governing the evolution of ice particles is the presence or absence of liquid water, which motivates the distinction between dry and wet snow metamorphism. The former occurs when the pores are filled only by air, typically saturated with water vapor. The main mechanisms underlying dry snow metamorphism are:

- *equilibrium growth*, driven by crystal shape. Local variations in surface curvature generate corresponding variations in equilibrium vapor pressure, inducing local pressure gradients that drive vapor from convex toward concave (or less convex) regions. Over time this transfer, sustained by sublimation on convex areas and

deposition on concave ones, rounds ice grains, driving snow crystals toward a spherical shape.

- *kinetic growth*, related to the presence of a temperature gradient. Because saturation vapor pressure depends strongly on temperature, such a gradient causes vapor to diffuse from the warmest crystals toward the coldest ones. Here too, sublimation on warm crystals and deposition on cold ones sustain the process, which, when the temperature gradient is strong enough, leads to the formation on facets.

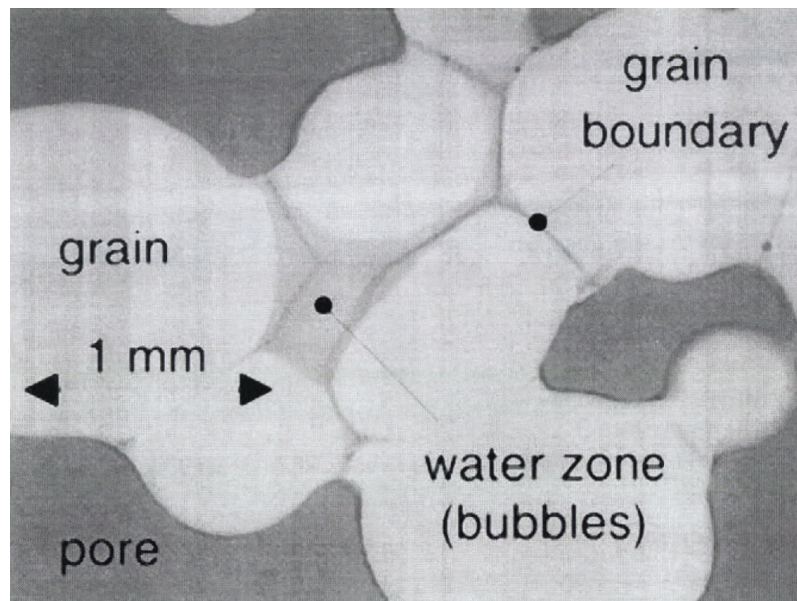


Figure 1.2: Thin section of wet snow under transmitted light, where ice grains delimit pore spaces containing both liquid water and air. The presence of air-filled pores suggest that the sample can potentially retain additional water. Image from Brzoska et al. [1998](#)

These two mechanisms are rarely mutually exclusive: they act simultaneously within the snowpack, with their relative strengths determined mainly by the magnitude of the local temperature gradient compared to the grain's curvature effect. In particular, the kinetic growth of snow particles is a matter of considerable concern in avalanche forecasting, since faceted crystals, if the temperature gradient persists over time, can evolve in depth hoar. This type of layer is notoriously weak and prone to failure, often resulting in large-scale avalanches.

When liquid water is present within the snowpack, the dynamics change substantially: mass exchanges between the three water phases become essential to understand wet snow metamorphism. The main driver of ice particles evolution is, once again, crystal surface curvature, with convex areas associated with lower melting point

temperatures. This topological property leads to the melting of the most convex surfaces and to refreezing on the more concave ones, driving ice particles towards the equilibrium spherical shape. The efficiency of this metamorphism channel is linked to the freedom water has to move within the snowpack: at very low water content mass exchanges between the solid and gaseous phases may still dominate.

Regardless of the specific metamorphic process involved, the evolution of ice crystals ultimately results in the compaction of the snow layer. Wind also plays a crucial role in increasing snow density, primarily through the fragmentation of snowflakes upon collision, which allows for a tighter packing of ice particles. Finally, gravity contributes to snow compaction as well, since buried snow layers must withstand an increasing load exerted by the weight of the overlying layers, resulting in higher deformation. The combined effects of metamorphism and deformation strain are typically described through a Newtonian viscosity approach. Snow viscosity depends on several parameters, including temperature, liquid water content and porosity and its values are generally retrieved by means of empirical relations. Overall, the density of older snow layers can easily exceed values of 400 kg m^{-3} , sometimes even reaching 500 kg m^{-3} in specific locations, depending on water content and time of the year (Jonas et al. 2009).

1.1.2 Snowpack energy balance

The evolution of a snowpack throughout the season is governed not only by the microphysical processes described above, but also by the exchange of energy between the snow cover, the atmosphere and the underlying ground. Neglecting horizontal energy transfers, the internal energy of the snowpack evolves in time as:

$$\frac{d\mathcal{H}}{dt} = R_N + H_S + H_L + H_P + G, \quad (1.1)$$

where $\mathcal{H}$ is the internal energy per unit area and R_N is the net radiative flux at the surface. H_S and H_L denote, respectively, the turbulent fluxes of sensible and latent heat, governed by the action of turbulent eddies within the boundary layer. H_P accounts for the energy exchange associated with precipitation, since rainfall carries additional heat that must be distributed within the snowpack. Finally, G represents the energy exchange with the ground, which is especially important during the deposition of the first snow layer. Each term in Equation (1.1) is expressed in W m^{-2} and, by convention, a positive sign indicates an energy flux directed into the snow layer. A schematic representation of the energy balance is provided in Figure 1.3: radiative contributions are discussed in more detail below.

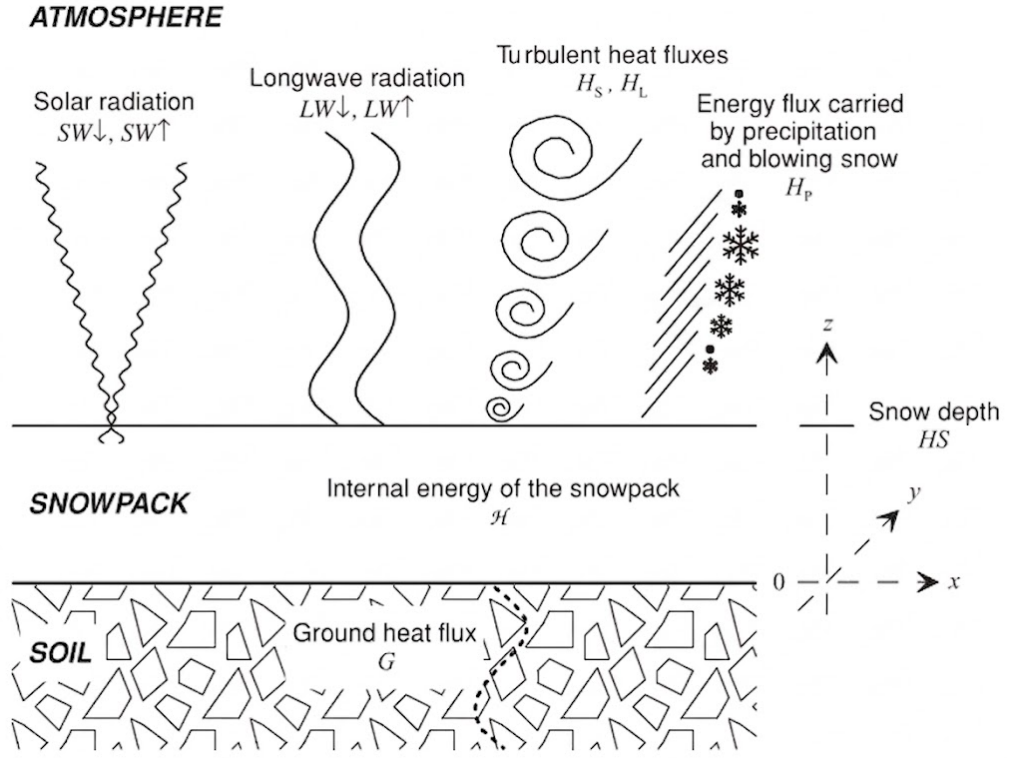


Figure 1.3: Schematic representation of the energy balance of a snowpack. Shortwave (SW) and longwave (LW) radiation, originating from the Sun and from thermal emission respectively, make up the net radiative budget R_N . The internal energy of the snowpack $\mathcal{H}$ can also be altered by the turbulent heat fluxes H_S and H_L , the precipitation heat flux H_P and the ground heat flux G . Image adapted from Armstrong and Brun 2008.

To fully understand the term R_N , it is essential to consider the dual nature of radiation in the atmosphere. Two distinct sources of radiation can in fact be identified: the Sun, with a surface temperature of around 5800 K, and the Earth-atmosphere system, whose temperature ranges from 200 K up to 350 K. According to the Wien's law, the two blackbody spectra peak respectively at roughly 0.5 μm and 10 μm with negligible overlap, thereby justifying a decoupled treatment of the two spectral domains. Solar radiation is commonly referred to as *shortwave* (SW), while the latter is known as *longwave* (LW). Therefore, the term R_N can be explicitly written as

$$R_N = SW \downarrow - SW \uparrow + LW \downarrow - LW \uparrow, \quad (1.2)$$

where a distinction is made between incoming and outgoing fluxes, as denoted by the direction of the arrows.

Incoming shortwave radiation is subject to absorption and scattering by atmospheric constituents. Consequently, the total SW radiation that reaches the Earth's surface is the sum of a direct beam transmitted through the atmosphere and a

diffuse component, resulting from multiple reflection and refraction events. The relative strengths of these two components is strongly dependent on meteorological and seasonal conditions. For example, at the lower solar altitudes typical of winter, the diffuse fraction is larger, since the solar beam must travel through a thicker atmospheric layer, increasing scattering probability. The same occurs at dawn or sunset, when the Sun is close to the horizon. Cloud cover also plays a significant role: under overcast conditions, up to 80% of $SW \downarrow$ can occur as diffuse radiation (DeWalle and Rango 2008). In the shortwave spectral range, snow features an exceptionally high reflectance, thanks to the combination of its microstructure with the optical properties of ice. The ratio between $SW \uparrow$ and $SW \downarrow$, commonly referred to as albedo α , typically exceeds 0.9 for freshly fallen snow, and decreases as impurities are deposited on the snow surface. This parameter is rather important, as it controls the amount of shortwave radiation absorbed, which generally represents the main source of energy for snowmelt. By albedo definition, this quantity can be calculated as

$$SW_{net} = SW \downarrow (1 - \alpha). \quad (1.3)$$

Even at advanced stages of the melt season, snow albedo remains considerably higher than that of the snow-free surroundings. As the snowpack retreats, this bright surface is replaced by darker ground, causing a significant α drop. This results in increased SW absorption, which causes further warming and, in turn, accelerates snowmelt itself in a self-reinforcing loop known as snow-albedo feedback.

Snow behaviour in the thermal infrared range, however, differs substantially from that in the shortwave domain. The snowpack absorbs nearly all incoming longwave radiation, emitted by atmospheric gases, clouds and the surrounding terrain, while radiating according to the Stefan-Boltzmann law and thus behaving as an almost perfect blackbody, with emissivities ranging from 0.97 to 0.99. Longwave radiation exchanges occur both during the day and at night, and are strongly influenced by meteorological conditions. In fact, water vapor significantly absorbs infrared light and, by Kirchhoff's law, is therefore also a strong emitter. As a result, clouds typically increase the downward longwave flux reaching the snow surface, thereby reducing the snowpack's radiative cooling capacity. This effect is especially pronounced at night, when the absence of the shortwave component would otherwise favor significant longwave losses.

Thanks to its relatively low thermal conductivity, the snowpack also shields the ground from rapid atmospheric temperature changes. This property is closely tied to snow microstructure and therefore evolves with metamorphism, as higher snow densities are associated with increased conductivity.

1.1.3 Snow melt and water runoff

The variations in internal energy $\mathcal{H}$, driven by the heat fluxes listed above, ultimately modify the thermal state of the snowpack and determine whether mass is lost through melting or sublimation. The snowpack temperature profile varies on both seasonal and daily scales, typically showing large gradients near the snow surface as a consequence of the low thermal conductivity of snow. The temperature oscillations of the first layers are damped rather quickly with depth, as the thermal state of the deeper bulk remains relatively stable. During winter, snowpacks typically exhibit subfreezing conditions, which poses a significant limitation to runoff generation. In fact, even when the surface temperature rises to 0°C and the energy balance is positive, the water produced by surface melting refreezes in deeper layers after some percolation. Although this process does not involve any mass loss, it effectively transports latent heat, warming the snowpack and reducing its cold content, which is the energy required to bring the whole snowpack to 0°C . This isothermal profile is eventually reached and, if a positive energy balance still persists, further melting contributes to filling the pores between ice crystals. This liquid water holding capacity is commonly reported ranging between 3% and 5% of the snowpack mass, although the exact value depends on the snow's porosity and microstructure. Once the water holding capacity is exceeded, the excess water percolates through the snowpack in a process that is mainly gravity driven. Because a typical snowpack is stratified into layers of contrasting grain size and permeability, water flow is rarely uniform as it tends to concentrate along preferential pathways known as flow finger, which are usually triggered by inhomogeneities in microstructure. Typical percolation velocities span more than an order of magnitude, ranging from 1 cm h^{-1} up to 20 cm h^{-1} . Ground conditions represent another critical factor in runoff evaluations, since meltwater can in principle infiltrate the soil. If the underlying surface is impermeable, such as frozen ground or bedrock, the excess water instead accumulates and flows downward along the base of the snow cover. If the snowpack is not isothermal throughout, part of this water may still refreeze, further warming the surroundings. The interplay between thermal conditioning, liquid water retention, and preferential flow pathways ultimately governs the timing, volume and rate of snowmelt runoff entering local stream networks.

In high elevation alpine catchments, or at high latitudes, some snow may survive melting through summer. If accumulation persists over multiple years, continued densification ultimately leads to the formation of firn, an intermediate stage between snow and ice characterized by densities ranging from 400 kg m^{-3} to 830 kg m^{-3} and by a porous structure that still permits water percolation. As compaction proceeds

further, most pores become sealed, marking the transition to glacier ice proper. The rate of this transformation depends on both accumulation amounts and temperature, since colder climates results in slower crystal evolution. This process directly links seasonal snow cover to the longer lived components of the cryosphere, such as glaciers and ice sheets (Cuffey and Paterson 2010).

1.2 Snow observation and measurement

A detailed knowledge of the snow cover and of its physical properties is a prerequisite for studying snowpack dynamics and for issuing reliable avalanche forecasts. Among the quantities routinely collected during snow measurement campaigns, snow depth (HS) plays a central role: it is defined as the vertical distance between the top of the snowpack and a reference surface, which for seasonal snowpacks is normally the ground. HS should not be confused with snow thickness (DS), which is conventionally the perpendicular distance to the same reference surface. Provided that the slope angle ϕ of the measurement site is known, the two quantities are related by

$$DS = HS \cos(\phi), \quad (1.4)$$

so that the two definitions coincide on flat terrain ($\phi = 0$) and progressively diverge as the slope steepens. The geometrical meaning of Equation (1.4) is illustrated in Figure 1.4. Both quantities are expressed in cm and are usually rounded to the nearest integer. While these metrics describe only the geometrical extent of the snowpack, other quantities provide deeper insight into its physical state. The most hydrologically relevant of these is snow water equivalent (SWE), namely the amount of water stored within the snowpack. Being closely related to snow density, it can be expressed as

$$SWE = \int_0^{HS} \rho_s(z) dz, \quad (1.5)$$

where $\rho_s(z)$ is the vertical density profile of the snowpack. The result is given in $\text{kg}^2 \text{m}^{-1}$, and can be converted in m (or mm) by dividing by the water density ρ_w . Although formally correct, Equation (1.5) is of limited practical use, since continuous knowledge of the density profile is generally unattainable. What can realistically be measured is the density of the individual layers, so that SWE is more commonly computed as

$$SWE = \sum_{i=1}^N \rho_i(z) \Delta z_i, \quad (1.6)$$

where N is the number of layers and Δz_i is the vertical extent of the i -th layer.

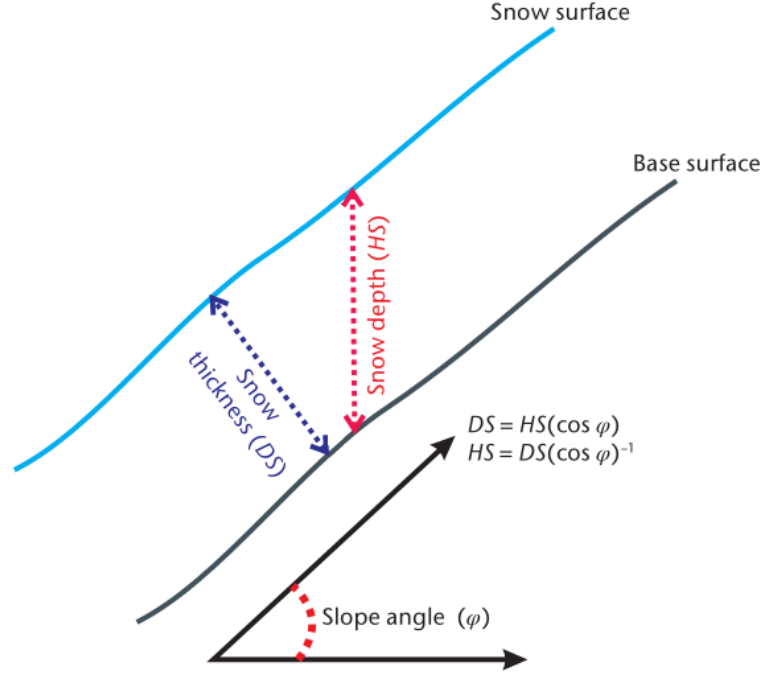


Figure 1.4: Relationship between snow depth (HS) and snow thickness (DS) on a slope. Image adapted from WMO 2024.

Historically, snow metrics were recorded manually, requiring an operator to carry out manual measurements on a daily basis whenever feasible. To ensure continuous data collection even in remote areas, automated weather stations (AWS) have been introduced and are progressively replacing manual observations as well. An automated monitoring network provides a comprehensive overview of snow conditions, but achieving high spatial resolution remains challenging due to high installation costs and maintenance issues. Consequently, certain data can only be obtained through remote sensing, by means of Earth-observing satellites.

While remote sensing provides spatially distributed data across entire regions, manual and automated measurements are taken at specific locations, which must be selected according to strict criteria. To ensure the reliability of these in situ observations, the monitoring site must match the features of the surrounding terrain. In alpine regions, monitoring sites must be free of large boulders and protected from excessive sun exposure, which can cause premature snowmelt and thus yield unrepresentative data. It is equally important to avoid locations prone to preferential snow accumulation driven by local wind patterns (WMO 2024).

1.2.1 Manual snow measurements

Manual snow depth (HS) records are an effective tool for assessing long-term trends, as they can span several decades. Their longevity is due to a straightforward measuring procedure, requiring only a stake or an extendible graduated rod. The snow stake should be vertical, painted white to minimize melt and fixed to the ground before accumulation begins. Snow depth observations should be made from a sufficient distance to avoid any deformation of the snowpack. Because the stake acts as an obstacle to wind and snow redistribution, localized mounds can form around it. Under such circumstances, operator must visually estimate the undisturbed snow surface to recover the actual HS value. For a non-fixed observation carried out with a graduated rod, the snow depth should be evaluated at the same location each time. The observer needs to ensure that the device, manually inserted into the snowpack, reaches the base surface without penetrating the soil, which would result in an overestimate of the actual HS. The rod must be vertical, and an estimate of the slope angle should be paired with every measurement.

Closely linked to snow depth is snowfall depth (HN), which can only be obtained manually. To avoid wind-induced bias this measurement should be carried out in a sheltered location, so that snow accumulates undisturbed on an artificial surface for the prescribed interval (usually 24 hours). Just before clearing the surface, thereby starting the next observation period, a ruler is inserted vertically into the freshly formed layer to obtain a depth measurement.

Although HS and HN define the vertical extension of the snowpack, hydrological applications rely mainly on the snow water equivalent (SWE): the two most common methods for manual measurement are snow pits and snow tubes. A snow pit consists of a hole manually dug into the snowpack down to a reference surface, usually the ground. Initially, the observer performs a stratigraphic analysis to gain deeper insight into the internal structure of the snowpack. The actual SWE measurement is conducted by inserting a sampler of known volume into the exposed snow face; the sample is then weighed to assess snow density. This procedure is usually repeated at multiple depths, either for each identified layer or at fixed spatial intervals, such as every 20 centimetres. This method enables the observer to reconstruct the snow density profile which, when combined with depth information, yields both the layer-by-layer and total snow water equivalent at that specific location. Clearly, the snow pit technique is disruptive and needs to be performed at a different site each time.

If the measurement campaign is focused on a spatial survey rather than a detailed, locally defined inspection, the logical choice is to use a snow tube, as it allows for rapid sampling of the entire snow column to directly retrieve the total SWE, sacrificing

layer-specific information. The snow tube must be inserted vertically into the snowpack until it reaches the ground. An estimate of the extracted core volume is made, and the average density is then computed by weighing the snow column. The conversion to SWE is then straightforward. This device should be used where the snow water equivalent is less spatially homogeneous, such at locations with heterogeneous exposure to both wind patterns and solar radiation.

1.2.2 Automatic snow monitoring

Networks of automatic weather station (AWS) require no manual intervention beyond routine maintenance and instrument calibration, and can provide continuous observations even in remote locations where human operation would be impractical. An AWS is typically equipped with a wide range of sensors, such as:

- ▶ *anemometer*, which measures wind speed. The blowing wind causes a small windmill, or a structure consisting of three cups mounted on a spindle, to rotate at a rate proportional to wind intensity. This quantity is particularly important, as empirical relations link it to turbulent heat fluxes, thus playing a significant role in energy balance considerations.
- ▶ *wind vane*, typically coupled with the anemometer to assess wind direction. It consists of a horizontal arm bearing a flat vertical vane at one end. Incoming wind gusts push against the vane, causing the arm to rotate freely until it aligns with the wind direction.
- ▶ *pyranometer*, which measures shortwave solar radiation. An AWS is typically equipped with both an upward and a downward facing pyranometer, in order to quantify incoming and outgoing SW radiation, thus enabling albedo estimates.
- ▶ *pyrgeometer*, which measures the longwave (infrared) radiation. Pyrgeometers likewise come in oppositely facing pairs, so that, combined with a pair of pyranometers, an evaluation of the net radiation balance of the surface is possible.
- ▶ *barometer*, used to evaluate the atmospheric pressure, a fundamental quantity for characterizing the dynamical state of the atmosphere.
- ▶ *thermo-hygrometer*, designed to simultaneously measure both air temperature and relative humidity at a given height above the ground (typically two meters).

- *rain gauge*, consisting of a circular collector and a funnel that channels the collected precipitation into a measuring device. In regions where solid precipitation is possible, the rain gauge may be heated in order to also evaluate the water equivalent of snowfall.

In alpine catchments and at high latitudes, these sensors are typically complemented by additional instruments specifically dedicated to snow monitoring. Mounted together on the same tripod or mounting structure, as shown in Figure 1.5, they constitute what is referred to as an alpine automatic weather station, a key tool for the study of snow related dynamics.

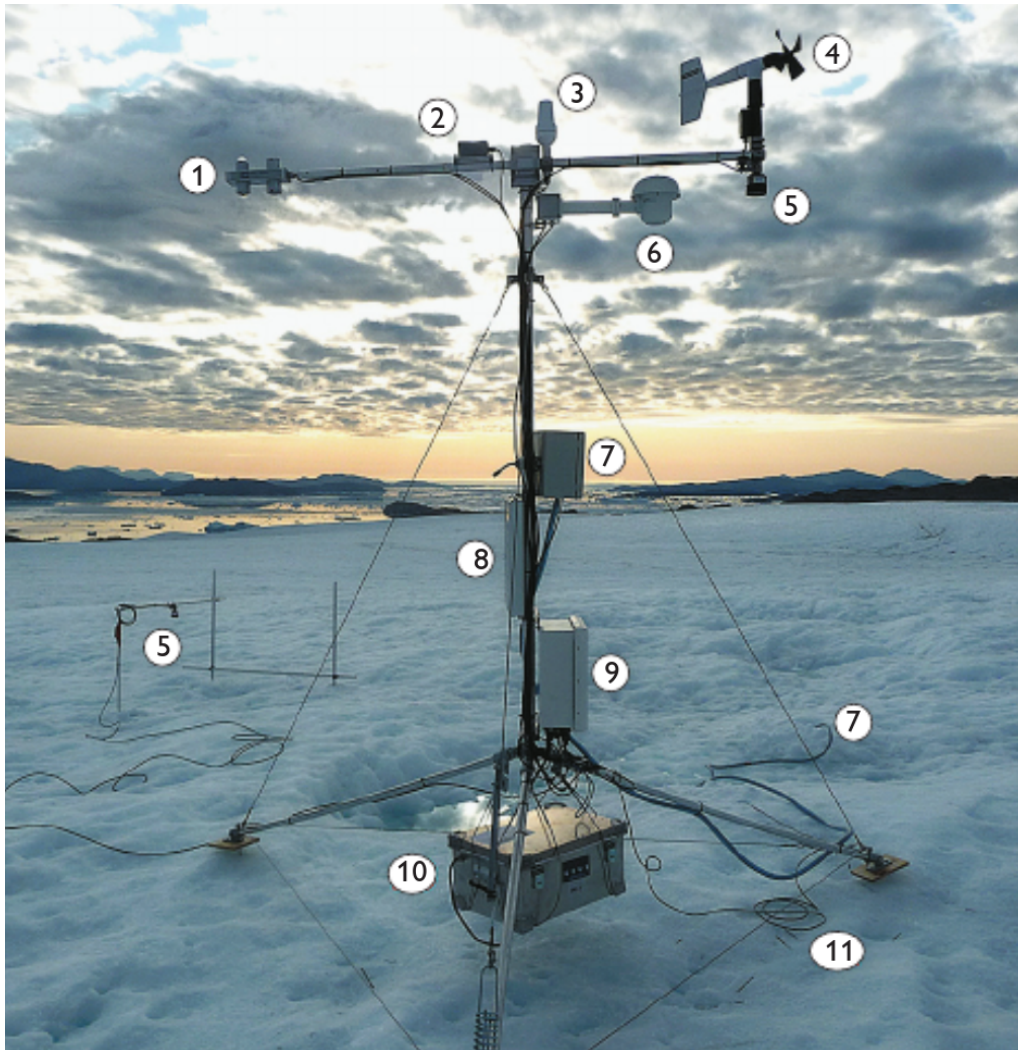


Figure 1.5: The AWS UPE_L which is part of an automated network of the Programme for Monitoring of the Greenland Ice Sheet (PROMICE). The constituents are respectively: (1) radiometer LW + SW, (2) inclinometer, (3) satellite antenna, (4) anemometer and wind vane, (5) snow depth sensor, (6) thermometer and hygrometer, (7) pressure transducer, (8) solar panel, (9) data logger and GPS, (10) battery box and (11) ground temperature sensor. Image adapted from Fausto and As [2012](#).

Automated HS measurements can be performed using instruments based on either sonic or optical (laser) technology. Sonic sensors transmit an ultrasonic pulse towards the snow surface and detect the returning echo. Since the speed of sound depends on meteorological conditions, a concurrent temperature reading is required to ensure accuracy. Laser instruments, by contrast, determine the distance to the target surface through interferometric analysis of the returned signal. This approach yields significantly higher precision, but at a grater energy cost.

In both cases, the sensor measures the distance to the upper surface of the snowpack, from which the snow depth is then derived as

$$\text{HS} = \text{Zero depth distance} - \text{Distance to target.} \quad (1.7)$$

The zero depth distance must be determined before snow accumulates and constitutes a key step in instrument calibration. To ensure reliable measurements, the sensor should be positioned well above the maximum expected snow depth, preventing burial and the consequent loss of data during winter. Minimizing interference from the support structure is equally important, since the mast itself acts as a wind obstacle and may induce measurement artefacts. For this reason, HS sensors are typically mounted on a horizontal arm stretching outward from the pole, keeping the target area sufficiently far from the mounting structure.

SWE monitoring can likewise be automated, with the most common technique relying on snow pillows. This device consists of a rubber bladder filled with an antifreeze liquid mixture and connected to a pressure transducer, which yields the SWE estimate. The pillow is installed flush with the ground surface, so that it supports the full weight of the overlying snowpack. As snow accumulates, the resulting increase in hydrostatic pressure is transduced into snow water equivalent values. Snow pillows were first introduced in the late 1960s, and have proved to be a valuable tool for SWE measurements (Beaumont 1965). However, they are now being progressively replaced by snow scales due to the toxicity of the antifreeze fluid, which poses an environmental hazard to the installation site.

1.2.3 Remote sensing

Satellite remote sensing (SRS) serves as a useful tool to fill critical gaps in current knowledge regarding climatic variables, enabling researchers to monitor, usually on a daily basis, even remote locations that would otherwise be inaccessible to a human operator. Furthermore, SRS data substantially improve meteorological reanalysis products, which constitute a cornerstone of contemporary climate change research.

Earth observing satellites can be classified into two distinct categories based on their orbital characteristics:

- ▶ Polar orbit satellites, which travel roughly from north to south over the poles, targeting a specific longitudinal strip per pass. The entire globe is thus mapped over consecutive orbits. These satellites typically operate at an altitude of approximately 700 km, completing a full revolution in under two hours.
- ▶ Geostationary satellites, which occupy a geosynchronous orbit, thereby allowing for real-time meteorological monitoring on a specific target area. Their altitude of approximately 36000 km above Earth's equator results in a significantly lower spatial resolution than that of polar orbit satellites.

The choice of orbit is strictly driven by observational priorities. Consequently, satellites dedicated to cryospheric research favor polar orbit, as maximizing spatial resolution is essential to capture the highly variable distribution of snow coverage across complex terrains.

Satellite-based observations of snow cover extent (SCE) began in 1967, through the efforts of National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA). This monitoring program focused on the Northern Hemisphere, where most of the world's terrestrial snow cover is found, with observations conducted on a weekly basis. Despite the preliminary nature of this work, it highlighted the strong latitudinal dependence of snow cover duration and paved the way for more comprehensive analyses. One of the main limitations of these early observations was their coarse spatial resolution of ~ 200 km, which was insufficient to adequately characterize snow cover in many mountainous regions (Bormann et al. 2018). A significant advance in sensor technology came with the introduction of the Advanced Very High Resolution Radiometer (AVHRR), which measures Earth radiance in five spectral bands to derive information on temperature, albedo and cloud coverage distribution. The first tests of a spaceborne sensor took place in 1978, but reliable snow cover data have only been available since 1981. This product has been used to estimate snow cover duration and trends since the mid-eighties in various mountainous regions such as the Alps, where SRS data reveal significantly negative trends throughout the 1990s, followed by a partial recovery at the beginning of the new millennium (Hüsler et al. 2014). Although AVHRR offers a substantial improvement in spatial resolution, with pixels of ~ 1 km, its data reliability is limited by the presence of only one thermal channel for snow-cloud discrimination (Fugazza et al. 2021). To overcome these limitations, the Moderate Resolution Imaging Spectroradiometer (MODIS) was launched in 1999 aboard the Terra satellite, followed by a second unit aboard

Aqua in 2002. Both instruments operate in polar orbit, jointly covering the entire globe every one to two days. MODIS is a 36-band spectral sensor spanning from the visible (0.41 μm) to the long-wave infrared (14.4 μm), with a spatial resolution of 500 m. To detect the presence of snow on the ground, the Normalized Difference Snow Index (NDSI) is used, defined as

$$\text{NDSI} = \frac{G - \text{SWIR}}{G + \text{SWIR}}, \quad (1.8)$$

where G and SWIR denote the green and shortwave infrared spectral bands respectively. This normalized difference approaches one for a snow-covered pixel, since snow exhibits very high reflectance in the visible portion of the electromagnetic spectrum, while strongly absorbing radiation in the SWIR. An NDSI value greater than zero indicates the presence of snow in the pixel; in practice, a threshold of 0.4, corresponding to roughly 50 % snow coverage, is commonly adopted to classify a pixel as snow covered (Salomonson and Appel 2006).

Although MODIS has proven to be a robust and well-validated tool for characterizing snow cover, the information it provides remains partial, as it is limited to detecting the presence or absence of snow on the ground. In order to assess how much water is stored in solid form, three main spaceborne techniques have been developed:

- *passive microwave radiometry (PMW)*, which is by far the most common method to remotely evaluate SWE. Since the snowpack attenuates the microwaves emitted by the Earth, comparing signal intensities between two frequencies (~ 18 GHz, and ~ 37 GHz) makes it possible to estimate snow water equivalent. This is the only spaceborne technique that allows for long term studies, as global daily maps have been available since the launch, in 1978, of NASA's Scanning Multichannel Microwave Radiometer (SMMR) (Schilling et al. 2024). Although the temporal coverage of these series is considerably better than that of other available sources, several factors affect data reliability, such as signal saturation caused by a deep snowpack.
- *gravimetric methods*, which offer a different approach focusing on mass changes. The accumulation of snow on the Earth's surface causes variations in its gravitational field, which can be converted into SWE estimates. This approach is mainly employed by the Gravity Recovery and Climate Experiment (GRACE) mission. Owing to its global coverage, this SWE dataset features a coarse spatial resolution of roughly 300 km, which nonetheless remains useful for continental scale hydrological studies (Schilling et al. 2024).

- *Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR)*, which consists in the transmission of electromagnetic waves towards Earth and the analyses of the backscattered echoes from the Earth's surface. SAR can penetrate cloud cover and acquire data under all weather conditions. Snowpack properties, such as SWE and snow grain size can be estimated remotely, as longer SAR wavelengths are even capable to penetrate into the snowpack. Furthermore, the phase information recorded by SAR can be exploited to monitor ground deformation and assess the stability of terrain features. Although SAR provides a spatial resolution on the order of tens of metres, its temporal resolution is significantly lower than that of PMW and gravimetric methods, as the revisit time of a specific location is typically five days (Tsai et al. [2019](#)).

1.3 Climate change

Climate change is conventionally defined as an alteration of the climate that can be attributed, directly or indirectly, to human activities that modify the composition of the global atmosphere. This phenomenon causes shifts in the mean and/or in the variability of temperatures and weather patterns, which can be identified through statistical tests and persist over an extended period of time, generally of at least thirty years. Since the anthropogenic signal is superimposed on the natural variability of the climate system, it must be disentangled from a background of spontaneous fluctuations. Over the past few million years, such natural fluctuations have produced a cyclic alternation between glacial periods, lasting roughly 100 000 years, and warmer interglacial conditions. These climatic oscillations were primarily driven by periodic variations in the orbital parameters governing Earth's revolution around the Sun, which caused slight changes in the amount of solar radiation reaching the surface. The effect of this weak radiative forcing on the planetary energy budget was amplified by snow albedo feedbacks, producing temperature changes large enough to modify the extent of the cryosphere on a global scale (Hays et al. [1976](#)).

The ongoing global warming, however, cannot be attributed to natural variability, as it is primarily driven by the large amounts of greenhouse gases released into the atmosphere by human activities. These gaseous compounds, of which carbon dioxide (CO₂) is the best known, partially absorb the longwave radiation emitted by Earth's surface and re-emit it in all directions. A fraction of this energy is thus returned to the surface instead of escaping to space, resulting in an increase in near-surface air temperature. Since the Industrial Revolution the atmospheric CO₂ concentration has risen steadily, from about 278 part per million (ppm) in pre-industrial times to

422.8 ppm in 2024 (NOAA [2025](#)). During the last 60 years, atmospheric CO₂ has risen nearly 100 times faster than during previous natural increases, and present day concentrations exceed those preserved in the ice core records of the last 800000 years, as shown in Figure 1.6.

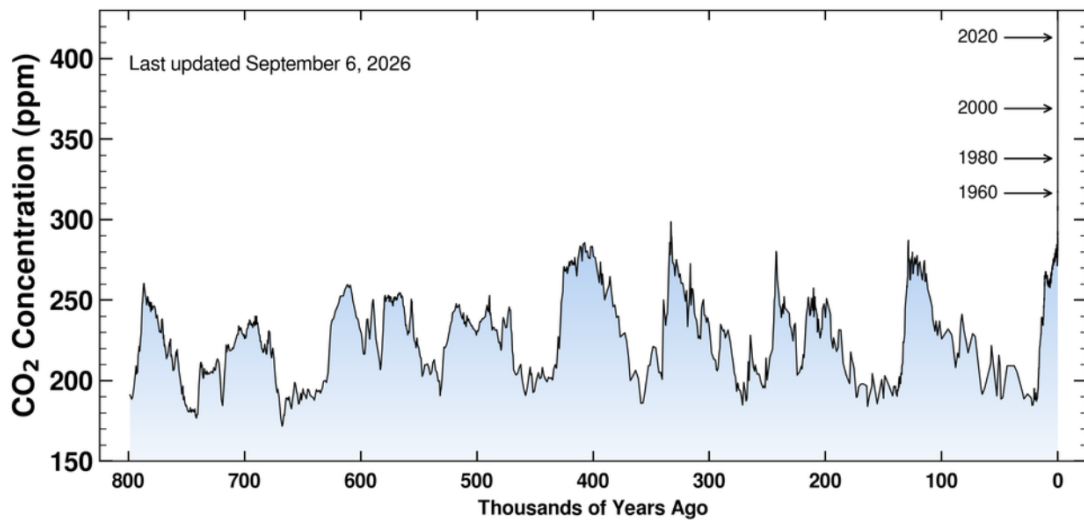


Figure 1.6: Evolution of CO₂ concentration in the atmosphere over the last 800000 years. Image adapted from Oceanography [2026](#).

Relative to the 1850–1900 climatology, the global mean surface air temperature observed over the 2010–2019 period was about 1.1 °C higher, and anthropogenic forcing alone is estimated to account for 0.9–1.3 °C of this increase, with the best estimate being 1.07 °C (Gillett et al. [2021](#)). The warming has also accelerated significantly in recent years, as the mean increase rate of roughly 0.18 °C per decade typical of the 1970–2010 period has nearly doubled between 2010 and 2023 (Hansen et al. [2025](#)). These trends are illustrated in Figure 1.7, which shows the global surface temperature anomaly relative to the 1880–1920 average.

1.3.1 Impacts on climate system

The increase in temperatures has significant consequences for every physical component of the climate system. A warmer atmosphere holds more water vapour, which provides additional moisture to storms and thus results in more intense precipitation events. At the same time, warming causes a greater share of precipitation to occur as rainfall instead of snowfall, increasing the risk of flooding in early spring and of droughts in summer, as less water is stored in seasonal snowpacks (Trenberth [2011](#)). Global warming also contributes to sea level rise: global mean sea level increased by 20 cm between 1901 and 2018 as a consequence of the thermal expansion of seawater

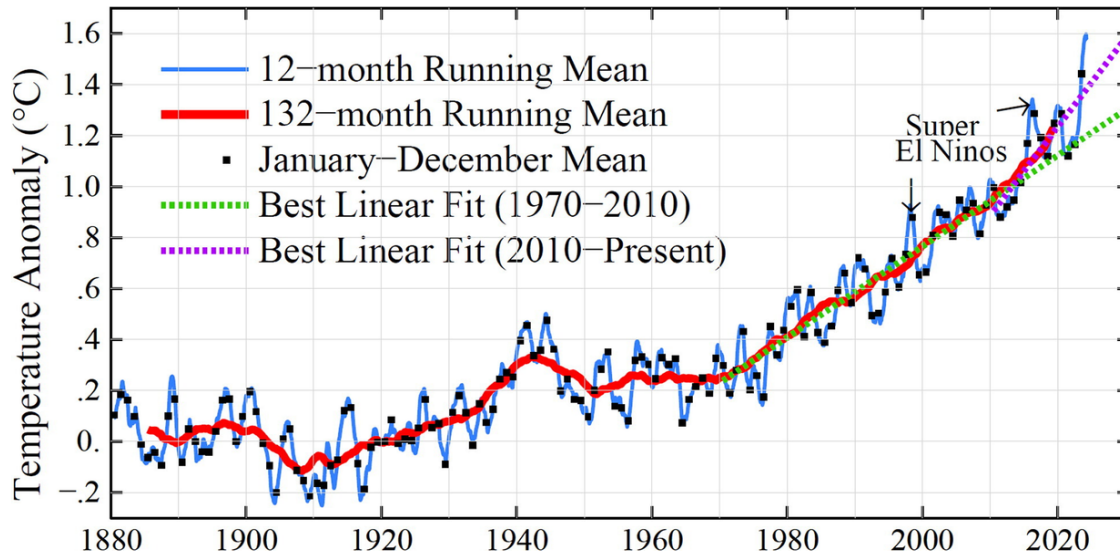


Figure 1.7: Global surface temperature anomaly relative to the 1880–1920 average. Adapted from Hansen et al. 2025.

and of the substantial melting of land based ice masses. The average rise rate nearly tripled over the last century, climbing from 1.3 mm year^{-1} over the 1901–1971 period to roughly 3.7 mm year^{-1} between 2006 and 2018. Furthermore, the continuous warming of the upper ocean layers results in more violent tropical storms and poses an existential threat to maritime ecosystems (IPCC 2023).

Among the many components of the climate system, the cryosphere is arguably the most sensitive to a warming planet, as it can thrive only in cold climates. Over the past four decades, the mean Arctic sea ice extent has been shrinking at an alarming rate of $54\,300 \text{ km}^2 \text{ year}^{-1}$, decreasing from approximately 12.5 million km^2 in 1979 to roughly 10.2 million km^2 in 2021 (Parkinson 2022). This decline is accompanied by a thinning of the ice layer and by a notable shortening of the sea ice season in the southernmost regions of the Arctic, as shown in Figure 1.8. Nowadays, the shores of Siberia remain ice-free for up to three months during summer, and comparable conditions are observed along the coasts of northern Canada. This marked reduction in the extent and persistence of sea ice is further worsening the climate crisis through a vigorous ice albedo feedback: as the disappearing sea ice is replaced by open water, which has a significantly lower albedo, more solar radiation is absorbed, leading to additional warming. Ice loss has also picked up in Greenland and Antarctic ice sheets, as the rate of mass loss has more than tripled with respect to the 1990s, surging from 105 Gt year^{-1} between 1992 and 1996 to 372 Gt year^{-1} between 2016 and 2020 (Mudryk et al. 2020). A similar figure emerges for mass loss of glaciers worldwide, which between 2000 and 2023 lost on average $273 \pm 16 \text{ Gt}$ annually (Zemp

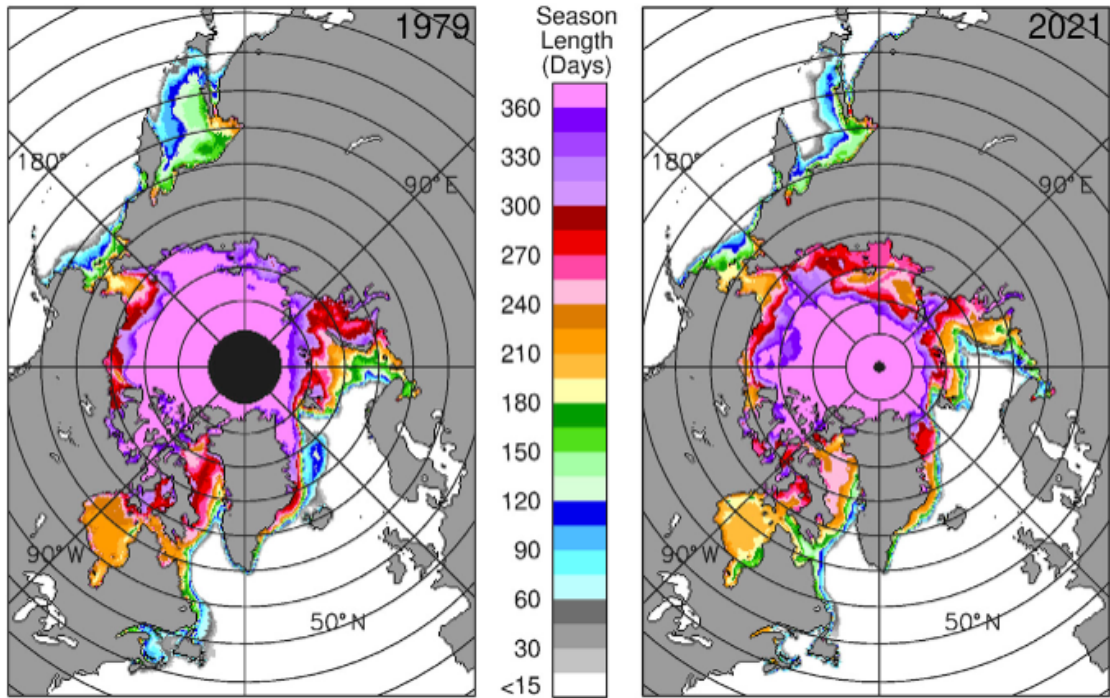


Figure 1.8: Comparison between the sea ice seasons in 1979 and 2021.
Image adapted from Parkinson [2022](#).

et al. [2025](#)). Mountain glaciers are particularly vulnerable to global warming, as rates of environmental change are typically enhanced by elevation. On a global scale, the differences between mountain and lowland trends are 0.21°C per century for temperature and -11.5 mm per century for total precipitation (Pepin et al. [2025](#)), implying that seasonal snowpacks and glacier ice in these regions will be further affected by a warming climate.

1.3.2 Impacts on the seasonal snow cover

The seasonal snow cover is clearly affected by the consequences of climate change, as air temperature determines whether precipitation falls in solid or liquid form and regulates the amount of energy available for melt. At the hemispheric scale, snow cover duration (SCD) shows a marked negative trend of -0.44 days year^{-1} (Roessler and Dietz [2023](#)). This decline can be attributed to an earlier onset of spring melt: over the 1967–2026 period, the mean snow covered area in April has been shrinking by 0.43 million km^2 per decade, that is by 1.44% per decade once normalized to the 1991–2020 mean. This loss rate is significantly larger in June, where the decadal reduction accounts for 14.51% of the corresponding monthly average, or to 1.18 million km^2 (NCEI [2026](#)). Total snow mass also exhibits a negative trend at the hemispheric scale, regardless of the period taken into account. This temporal trends,

however, show a significant spatial variability, as peak snow mass over North America is currently declining by -46 Gt per decade, whereas no significant trend is detected over Eurasia, where losses on the European portion are compensated by enhanced snowfall in Siberia. This increase in snow mass over Northern Russia is also driven by climate change, as warmer air has a higher water holding capacity causing a shift in precipitation patterns (Pulliainen et al. 2020).

A similar picture emerges when focusing on mountainous regions, as aggregate trends over global mountain areas are slightly negative, with an average reduction in snow cover extent of $3.6 \pm 2.7 \%$ and a decrease in snow cover duration of 15.6 ± 11.6 days over the 1982–2020 period. Despite the overall reduction at the global scale, the results show substantial spatial variability across mountain ranges and some positive trends driven by climatic forcing may still occur, as visible in Figure 1.9. For instance,

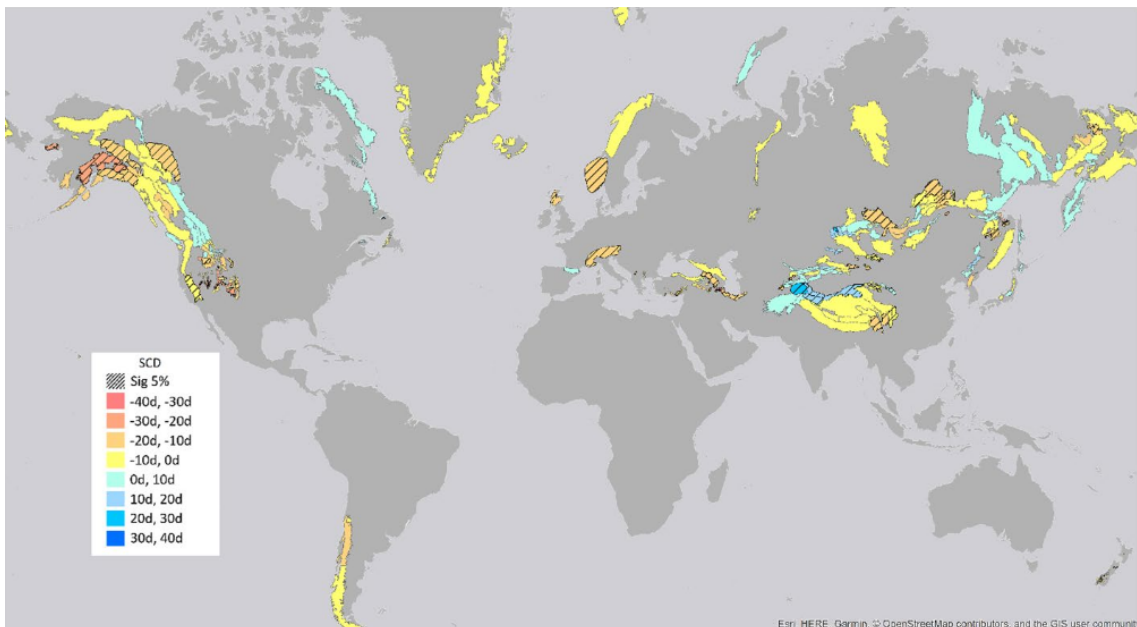


Figure 1.9: Trends in snow cover duration over mountainous terrain between 1982 and 2020. Underlined areas indicate trends that are significant at 95% confidence level. Image adapted from Notarnicola 2022.

the snow cover duration across the Pamir range has been increasing up to 27.4 days between 1982 and 2020 as a result of changes in the winter westerly disturbance, whereas the neighboring Himalayas experienced significant losses (Notarnicola 2022).

Within this heterogeneous picture the European Alps emerge as a particularly critical region. This vulnerability arises from the combined effects of their mid-latitude location and relatively modest elevations, which cause a substantial fraction of the snowpack to remain close to the melting point throughout the snow season. Under such conditions, even a slight increase in air temperature can lead to sudden

changes in snowfall and snow ablation patterns. This is documented by the Swiss meteorological network, whose records show a clearly decreasing trend in the ratio of snowfall days to precipitation days between 1961 and 2008. In particular, present day values for December, January, and February are similar to those observed in November and March during the 1960s, and the decline is more pronounced below 1400 m a.s.l., where winter temperatures are already close to 0°C (Serquet et al. 2013). The same elevation dependence is found in snow depth across the entire European Alps: below 1000 m a.s.l. the average HS over November-May decreased by up to 10 % per decade between 1971 and 2019, whereas above 2000 m a.s.l. the reduction was only about 2.4 % every ten years. This asymmetry is reflected in the duration of snow cover, which over the same period shortened on average by 6.5 % per decade below 1000 m a.s.l. and just by 0.5 % per decade above 2000 m of elevation (Matiu et al. 2021). The shortening of the snow season is driven, as on the hemispherical scale, by an earlier melt-out of the snowpack, rather than by a delayed onset of snow accumulation. This phenomenon, combined with a declining amount of water stored within the snowpack, is causing a shift in the hydrological cycle potentially exposing millions of people to summer droughts, as the snowmelt contribution to streamflow is no longer sufficient to compensate water deficits later in the season.

Model projections suggest that these negative trends will persist throughout the century, as a further decrease in seasonal snowpack extent, depth and SWE is certain regardless of elevation and emission scenario. Mountainous areas below 1200 m a.s.l. will be the most affected, with simulations showing almost snow free conditions by the end of the century. In a non-intervention scenario, significant losses are projected to affect the highest peaks as well, with a decrease in HS by about 50 % above 3000 m of elevation. Under these circumstances, the accompanying changes in snow cover patterns would be roughly equivalent to an upward elevation shift of 750 m. By contrast, a substantial cut in greenhouse gas emissions would eventually lead to a stabilization in snow characteristics around the turn of the twenty-second century, with losses settling at about 30 % relative to present day rather than the 70 % projected if no action were taken (Marty et al. 2017).

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